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ENGL 225 Shakespeare: Beyond Tragedy

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“I Am Greater than a King”: Richard’s Plot for Unchecked Power

In Act 3 Scene 3 of Shakespeare’s *Richard II*, tension reaches a climax as Henry Bolingbroke, backed by an army of nobility and commoners, finally encounters an isolated King Richard. Although Bolingbroke has claimed he only wants his inheritance that Richard confiscated, Richard understands that the kingdom is unsatisfied with his kingship and that his deposition is imminent. He sends Northumberland to tell Bolingbroke that he may have what he wants, and while waiting for a response, Richard characteristically monologues:

What must the King do now? Must he submit?
The King shall do it. Must he be deposed?
The King shall be contented. Must he lose
The name of King? In God’s name let it go.
I’ll give my jewels for a set of beads,
My gorgeous palace for a hermitage,
My gay apparel for an almsman’s gown,
My figured goblets for a dish of wood,
My sceptre for a palmer’s walking staff,
My subjects for a pair of carved saints
And my large kingdom for a little grave, [...]
Aumerle, thou weep’st, my tender-hearted cousin.
We’ll make foul weather with despised tears.
Our sighs and they shall lodge the summer corn
And make a dearth in this revolting land.
Or shall we play the wontons with our woes
And make some pretty match with shedding tears?
As thus: to drop them still upon one place
Till they have fretted us a pair of graves
Within the earth and, therein laid, “There lies
Two kinsmen digged their graves with weeping eyes”.
Will not this ill do well? Well, well, I see
I talk but idly and you laugh at me.
Most mighty prince, my lord Northumberland,
What says King Bolingbroke – will his majesty
Give Richard leave to live till Richard die?

You make a leg and Bolingbroke says “Ay”. (3.3.142-174)

In this monologue, Richard claims that he is surrendering his kingship to Bolingbroke and will either live a humble life or be executed. However, the passage “We’ll make foul weather with despised tears. / Our sighs and they shall lodge the summer corn / And make a dearth in this revolting land” (3.3.161-163) complicates this claim. In the previous scene, Richard commanded nature to “Feed not thy sovereign’s foe” and to fight Bolingbroke’s armies with venomous animals “ere her native king / Shall falter under foul rebellion’s arms” (3.2.12-26). Why would Richard claim that he can control nature even after his resignation if it is a power given to the king? Although this could be idle rambling to cheer up his depressed cousin Aumerle, there is more evidence that Richard sees his resignation as an opportunity to escape responsibility while keeping the divine powers of a king.

Richard’s resignation is a chance to escape the expectations and coercion of the royal court. The monologue begins with Richard describing his limited autonomy, repeating that he will do what he “must”: “submit,” “be deposed,” and “lose / The name of king” (3.3.142-145). This mirrors the odd restriction on Richard’s powers introduced at the start of the play, where Richard states, “We were not born to sue, but to command, / Which [here] we cannot do” (1.1.196-197). Although kings are all-powerful, Richard constantly expresses that he is being limited or controlled. Because Richard was often “not himself but basely led / By flatterers” (2.1.241-242), this commentary by Richard could reveal that he knows he is being manipulated, and that he wants to be free. If Richard resigns, the nobility would have to appeal to Bolingbroke for their desires; Richard would be newly independent and unmanaged. This reading is supported by the fact that after the line “In God’s name let [the name of King] go” (3.3.145), Richard refers

to himself in first-person or by “Richard” for the rest of his monologue. He is no longer a figurehead or a symbol; he has been reborn into an autonomous human being.

Even further, Richard illustrates his orchestration of his own rebirth by the imagery of tears digging a grave. Throughout the play, graves and the earth have been compared to wombs, with Bolingbroke calling English soil the mother of Englishmen (1.3.306-307) and Gaunt calling himself “gaunt as a grave / Whose hollow womb inherits naught but bones” (2.1.82-83). Mixing water with this grave-womb metaphor evokes both the imagery of a womb’s water breaking and of a baptism, reinforcing Richard being reborn. Crying himself a grave, Richard himself is responsible for reconstructing himself, despite the message at the beginning that he “must [...] be deposed” (3.3.143) and will do what he is told.

As Richard gives up the life of a king, how much does he actually surrender? When Richard lists how much he is willing to forgo, each loss is placed on its own line, giving the impression that he is yielding everything he has. He claims that he will replace his beautiful items with humble versions, such as his “gay apparel for an almsman’s gown” (3.3.148), as well as lose his land and subjects. Does this mean that Richard believes that a king is defined by his material wealth and subjects’ loyalty? If he does, then Bolingbroke—who networks with the populace and receives a large inheritance—is the perfect candidate to make a king. However, there remains a blatant absence in Richard’s concessions: he does not give up his God-given powers.

Returning to the initial complication, Richard, despite claiming to relinquish the crown, assumes he is still supernaturally powerful. The sun and rain are recurring motifs for both Bolingbroke and Richard throughout the play, so if Richard’s emotions are “foul weather” that “lodge the summer corn” (3.3.160-161), Richard becomes rain and Bolingbroke the sun, and Richard directly undermines Bolingbroke’s power. Although Richard is orchestrating this

resignation, he has painted it as something being forced on him (“Must he be deposed?” 3.3.143), and it would be odd to not want to fight back, and Richard does not have to like Bolingbroke while he makes him king. However, why did Richard describe his rebellion as a mystical storm instead of a physical fight or a political coup? As previously stated, this description of fighting back could be an attempt to make Aumerle feel better in a hopeless situation, as Richard states, “I talk but idly and you laugh at me” (3.3.170). However, this line could be a response to the return of Northumberland mentioned in the next line. In order to escape responsibility without being executed, Richard has to appear too weak to fight Bolingbroke or the deposement, so in front of Northumberland, Richard undercuts his description of fighting back by calling it idle chatter. Richard cannot mentally separate himself from his royal divinity, and he can genuinely imagine himself calling the land to rebel against Bolingbroke.

Richard’s use of meter also supports the idea that he sees himself as in control of the flow of nature. The line “What says King Bolingbroke – will his majesty” (3.3.172) has only nine syllables, the only deviation from iambic pentameter in this monologue. The surrender of the crown to Bolingbroke offends the divine right to rule and hereditary succession so much, time stops for one beat. Alternatively, Richard sees himself as so powerful, he does not need to obey the norm of iambic pentameter.

This monologue serves as a major turning point of the play, with Richard autonomously creating for himself a new, unmanaged life while simultaneously claiming that his deposement is unfairly forced upon him. By constructing the narrative himself, Richard has the privilege to decide what aspects of kingship he can keep even after resigning, including divine powers. Further analysis of this monologue could discuss how Richard describes his new life as

religiously motivated and how he relates himself to Jesus in future scenes, despite the fact that his resignation offends God's right to choose kings. Richard's monologue demonstrates his intense motivation to retain control "till Richard die" (3.3.173).